

Saikat Chakraborty

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The Indian men's hockey team stumbled in its first attempt to secure a spot at the 2026 World Cup, dropping to seventh in the world after a dismal European leg of the FIH Pro League 2024-25.

One win from eight matches and a record seven-game losing streak — the longest in India's history — turned a side once seen as title contender into one relieved to cling to its top-tier status.

Now, as Craig Fulton's men shift focus to the Asia Cup in Rajgir, Bihar, a World Cup qualifier and, in the coach's words, the "most important tournament of the year" — the question is whether the Pro League collapse was an aberration or a symptom of deeper problems.

The burden of expectations

India enters the tournament as a three-time champion, the highest-ranked side, and Asia's flag-bearer in world hockey. That pedigree brings both opportunity and pressure: the need to reassert dominance on the continental stage while silencing doubts about its recent slide.

Defensive frailties

Fulton's "defend-to-attack" philosophy, built on fitness and quick transitions, fell apart in Europe. India conceded 26 goals across eight games, undone by slack clearances, mistimed tackles, and poor positioning inside the defensive 'D'. Six of those seven defeats came by a single goal, five of them in the final quarter.

Yet Fulton remains optimistic. "Over the last 18 months, we've been on the up," he told *Sportstar*. "Yes, we had a bit of a [bad] phase, but it



Indian squad for men's Asia Cup 2025

GOALKEEPERS: Krishan B Pathak, Suraj Karkera

DEFENDERS: Sumit, Jarmanpreet Singh, Sanjay, Harmanpreet Singh, Amit Rohidas, Jugraj Singh

MIDFIELDERS: Rajinder Singh, Raj Kumar Pal, Hardik Singh, Manpreet Singh, Vivek Sagar Prasad.

FORWARDS: Mandeep Singh, Shilanand Lakra, Abhishek, Sukhjeet Singh, Dilpreet Singh

ALTERNATES: Nilam Sanjeep Xess, Selvam Karthi

K. MURALI KUMAR

